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GOD AND CHRISTIAN EXISTENCE IN THE PASTORAL EPISTLES: TOWARD *THEOLOGICAL* METHOD AND MEANING

by

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1. *Christology and Theology in Balance*

"Has the emphasis upon the figure of Christ gone too far?" C. K. Barrett raises this provocative question following a brief survey of trends in his study of John's theological center.¹ Writing in the mid-seventies, Barrett chronicles a trend moving away from R. Bultmann's anthropological focus, a trend he seems to support, to the Christocentric positions of H. Conzelmann and E. Käsemann. However, Barrett wonders aloud as to whether this shift, as laudable as it is, has still missed a crucial emphasis in John. "It seems to me," Barrett argues, "that we must now, without abandoning either anthropology or Christology, go on to speak of theology in the strict sense of the term."² John is writing about, and directing our attention to, God."³

Without going further into the particulars of Barrett's case, a case can be made for raising similar concerns with reference to the Pastoral Epistles (hereafter, PE). Scholarship in the PE is breaking from the bonds of earlier, largely derogatory perspectives regarding the coherency and quality of the PE's theology. There is a developing consensus among scholars working in these letters that they are something more than A. T. Hanson's "ingenious pastiche"⁴ or J. D. G. Dunn's "fading vision."⁵ Although we would not want to argue that there is a firm

¹ "Christocentric or Theocentric? Observations on the Theological Method of the Fourth Gospel" in *Essays on John* (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1982) 2. "Christocentric and Theocentric" first appeared in *La Notion Biblique de Dieu*, ed. J. Coppens (Gembloux: Duculot/Leuven: University Press, 1976).

² Hereafter, "theology" will be used as a designation for "theology in the strictest sense."

³ "Christocentric or Theocentric," 3.

⁴ *The Pastoral Epistles* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1982) 47.

⁵ *Jesus and the Spirit. A Study of the Religious and Charismatic Experience of Jesus and the First Christians as Reflected in the New Testament* (London: SCM, 1964) 348-349. See also

consensus as to what, exactly, constitutes the character of the author's theological framework, to whatever extent he has adopted traditional materials, the area to which many appeal as the proof of PE's inferior character,⁶ it seems increasingly clear that he has carefully framed and augmented these pieces to provide a coherent theological perspective.⁷ Moreover, a convincing case has been made for understanding his theological framework as the basis for his ethical stance and as a pointed attack against the position of the antagonists, although variously perceived, found in these letters.⁸ At the same time, with this renewed attention to the coherency of the letters' theological framework has come an increasing emphasis on their christology, and secondarily, their soteriology (and even here, these studies seem predominately interested in christologically focused soteriology), without a similar focus on their *theology*.⁹ Thus, christologically/soteriologically oriented studies of the PE have proliferated in recent scholarship and, with rare exception, little has been said about the *theology* of these letters outside of its relevance to christology. There appears to be a need for a careful description of and an accounting for the author's view of God in relationship to the argument and situation envisioned by the letters. While this author would not want to say that the emphasis on Christ has gone "too far," it does seem that the emphasis on *theology* in studies of the PE has not gone "far enough."

J. D. G. Dunn's *Unity and Diversity in the New Testament. An Enquiry into the Character of Earliest Christianity* (London: SCM, 1977) 69-70, 115.

⁶ See I. H. Marshall, "'Sometimes Only Orthodox'—Is there more to the Pastoral Epistles," *EpRev* 20/3 (1993) 12-24.

⁷ "There is an increasing body of evidence that the Pastoral Epistles are not a conglomerate of miscellaneous ideas roughly thrown together with no clear plan, purpose or structure. On the contrary, they demonstrate signs of a coherent structure and of theological competence" (I. H. Marshall, "The Christology of Acts and the Pastoral Epistles" in *Crossing the Boundaries*, ed. S. Porter et al. [Leiden: Brill, 1996] 171). As an example of such "evidence" Marshall cites P. Towner's work, *The Goal of Our Instruction: The Structure of Theology and Ethics in the Pastoral Epistles* (JSNTSS 34; Sheffield: Academic Press, 1989). On the author's conservative, yet creative use of tradition generally, see A. Lau, *Manifest in the Flesh: The Epiphany Christology of the Pastoral Epistles* (WUNT 2.86; Tübingen: Mohr/Siebeck, 1996) 178-9; E. Ellis, "Traditions in the Pastoral Epistles" in *Early Jewish and Christian Exegesis*, ed. C. A. Evans & W. F. Stinespring (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1987) 237-53; and H. Stettler, *Die Christologie der Pastoralbriefe* (WUNT 2.105; Tübingen: Mohr/Siebeck, 1998) 1, 295-7.

⁸ In addition to Towner, *Goal*, see also F. Young, *The Theology of the Pastoral Epistles* (Cambridge: University Press, 1994); L. Donelson, *Pseudepigraphy and Ethical Argument in the Pastoral Epistles* (HUT 22; Tübingen: Mohr, 1986); and R. Kidd, *Wealth and Beneficence in the Pastoral Epistles* (SBLDS 122; Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1990).

⁹ See the sources cited by I. H. Marshall, "The Christology of the Pastoral Epistles," *Studien zum Neuen Testament und seiner Umwelt* 13 (1988) 157-8.

The warrant for a closer attention to the PE *theology* is supported by recent developments within pauline studies generally and by the data in the letters themselves.¹⁰ In pauline studies the attention to *theology* as a concern in its own right is supported by recent studies of the centrality of God in Paul's thought, particularly in reference to Romans.¹¹ In fact L. Morris argues that God is the theme of Romans and mentions, in the course of his study, that forty percent of all the occurrences of θεός in the New Testament appear in Paul's letters.¹² To speak of the PE alone, it has long been recognized that something rather dramatic happens to Paul's usual way of speaking of God. Although a number of recognized ways of speaking of God are to be found,¹³ God is primarily and uniquely, in reference to the Pauline corpus, identified as σωτήρ (1 Tim. 1:1; 2:3; 4:10; Tit. 1:3; 2:10; 3:4). In addition God's sovereignty and transcendence are strikingly emphasized in the doxology of 1 Tim. 1:17 as well as in the extended description of God preceding the brief doxology in 6:15-16. To mention just one more example, there is the repeated appearance of ἐνώπιον τοῦ θεοῦ, accompanied at times by additional descriptions of God and other heavenly figures, as a component of an adjuration formula (1 Tim. 5:21; 6:13; 2 Tim. 2:14; 4:1).¹⁴

With these factors in view, the purpose of this study is to make a

¹⁰ While the present author is persuaded that the theology and occasion entailed in these letters can be explained most economically with reference to the Apostle Paul and his lifetime, the views presented herein are in no way dependent upon such a view. As the following study will demonstrate, it is an attempt to do justice to the uniqueness of 1 Timothy and not an attempt to harmonize the letter with Paul. As a representative sample of the many able defenses of their authenticity, see G. W. Knight, *Commentary on the Pastoral Epistles* (NIGTC; Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1992) 1-52; G. D. Fee, *1 & 2 Timothy, Titus* (NIBC 13; Peabody: Hendrickson, 1988) 1-31; and L. T. Johnson, *The Writings of the New Testament: An Interpretation* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1986) 381-407.

¹¹ See L. Morris, "The Theme of Romans" in *Apostolic History and the Gospel*, ed. W. W. Gasque & R. P. Martin (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1970) 249-63; H. Moxnes, *Theology in Conflict: Studies of Paul's Understanding of God in Romans* (NovTSup 53; Leiden: Brill, 1980); A. C. Wire, "Pauline Theology as an Understanding of God: The Explicit and the Implicit" (Ph.D. dissertation, Claremont, 1974); and P. Perkins, "God in the New Testament: Preliminary Soundings," *Today* 42 (1985) 332-41.

¹² "Romans," 250-2. See also his article, "The Apostle Paul and His God" in *God who is Rich in Mercy*, ed. P. O'Brien & D. Peterson (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1986) 165-78.

¹³ God is referred to as Father (1 Tim. 1:2; 2 Tim. 1:2; Tit. 1:4), the living God (1 Tim. 3:15; 4:10), Creator (1 Tim. 4:3-4; cf. 6:13), King (1 Tim. 1:17; 6:15), Lord (1 Tim. 6:15; 2 Tim. 1:18; 2:19; cf. 1 Tim. 1:14), and the object of the believer's hope (1 Tim. 4:10; 5:5; 6:17).

¹⁴ See G. Stählin, "Zum Gebrauch von Beteuerungsformeln im Neuen Testament," *NovT* 5/6 (1962/63) 115-43.

contribution to a better understanding of the *theology* in the PE. In particular it will focus on the striking descriptions of God in 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16 with regard to the conception of God that is revealed therein and with regard to the function of these passages within the letter as a whole. First, a brief survey of two notable, but very divergent, perspectives on the PE's *theology* will allow us to focus the study in light of current interpretive options. In particular, these studies will help provide the conceptual parameters for a crucial component of the PE's *theology*, i.e. the epiphanic language.¹⁵ Second, there will be a brief treatment of the nature of the opposition depicted in the PE in order to provide an internal check against which the relevance of our later *theological* conclusions can be tested. The operating assumption here is that the author's *theology* is fashioned in response to the situation encountered in the letters. Third, the theological concepts and relationships between chapters one and six will be explored in order to demonstrate their inter-connectedness as key to understanding the nature and function of the elaborate descriptions of God in these chapters. Finally, conclusions will be offered concerning the nature and function of the PE's *theology* which arise in connection to the elaborate descriptions of God in 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16. In sum it is the contention of this study that the author of the PE has strategically placed each elaborate description of God as well as characterized God with a uniform emphasis in order to reinforce God's sovereign control of salvation-history. And by so doing, he is able to counteract the alternative perspective on how God saves and to invest Timothy's (and the church's at Ephesus through him) experience with the already/not yet eschatological tension, since his life falls inbetween the inauguration and consummation of this present age in God's οἰκονομία (1 Tim. 1:4).

2. *Current Theologically Concerned Studies*

The work of V. Hasler is one of the few exceptions to the prevailing christological focus of the recent literature that sees the PE's author to be a theologian in his own right. Hasler argues that the author of the PE has departed from the salvation-historical and apocalyptic framed gospel of Paul by adopting the revelatory perspective

¹⁵ This terminology (ἐπιφάνεια, ἐπιφάνης, ἐπιφαίνω) although not unique to the PE in the NT (cf. Luke 1:79; Acts 2:20; 27:20; 2 Thess. 2:8), is especially prominent in these letters (1 Tim. 6:14; 2 Tim. 1:10; 4:1,8; Tit. 2:11,13; 3:4) and, by its very nature, is particularly germane to the present study.

of Hellenistic syncretism, an “Offenbarungstheologie.”¹⁶ As a result, God, not Christ, is put in the spotlight. God is exalted and Christ is changed into a mere manifestation of God’s grace.¹⁷ Christ loses his independent status as Savior since he fulfills only a functional role in making known God’s salvific plan. It is the transcendent God, a conception of God which the author has taken from the Stoically influenced Diaspora synagogue,¹⁸ who saves universally, a salvation that is to be understood as the granting of eternal life following the assessment of one’s works by the Lord (Christ) at the final judgment. For Hasler then, christology is swallowed up by *theology* as the author recasts Paul’s gospel in accordance with his own, syncretistically tainted, conception of God.

An alternative perspective is offered by A. Lau as an offshoot of his study on the character of the epiphany christology in the PE.¹⁹ After establishing the PE’s conservative, Paul-like approach to tradition, Lau argues that it is very unlikely (*contra* Hasler) that the author would treat traditional conceptions so cavalierly as to metamorphose them into something foreign to their original import. This leads him to look for an alternative model for, and understanding of, the author’s epiphanic language which could be more easily understood in light of recognized pauline emphases within the author’s chosen christological traditions as well as his conservative approach toward handling them. His search leads him to re-examine current views of epiphanic language in Greco-Roman religious contexts²⁰ and, most importantly, to a close reading of Hellenistic-Jewish 2 Maccabees. From the Greco-Roman sources he notes various occasions where epiphanic terminology is used to describe not only a helping intervention by the deity in question, but a visible appearance as well.²¹ In 2 Maccabees, Lau finds the consistent devel-

¹⁶ “Epiphanie und Christologie in den Pastoralbriefen,” *TZ* 33 (1977) 193-209, see esp. 201.

¹⁷ “Epiphanie”, 200.

¹⁸ “Epiphanie”, 195.

¹⁹ See note 7 above.

²⁰ In particular Lau has his sights fixed on the treatment of epiphanic terminology by D. Lührmann, “Epiphaneia. Zur Bedeutungsgeschichte eines griechischen Wortes” in *Tradition und Glaube*, ed. G. Jeremias *et al.* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1971) 185-99. Lührmann attempts to undermine earlier studies of this terminology (esp. E. Pax, *ΕΠΙΦΑΝΕΙΑ: Ein religionsgeschichtlicher Beitrag zur biblischen Theologie* [Münchener Theologische Studien 40; München: Karl Zink, 1955]) which had suggested that epiphanic terms could express the visible appearance of a deity. Lührmann grants the historical and datable character of the epiphanies. But rather than understanding them as claims for a visible appearance of a deity, these should be understood more generally as “göttliche Hilfe” (195-6, 198).

²¹ *Manifest*, 182-8, 223.

opment of a “leitmotif of ἐπιφάνεια” concerning which the interpretive backdrop is not that of Hellenistic syncretism.

While the Epitomist has formulated his work in accordance with such a (Hellenistic) framework and has adopted Hellenistic conventions, he has unequivocally stamped the epiphanic language and allusions with his strong OT monotheistic understanding of God’s redeeming acts and manifestations vis-à-vis the polytheistic ἐπιφάνεια of the neighboring religions. These manifestations are expressed in manners corresponding to the OT theophanic notion, reminiscent of the angel(s)-of-the-Lord or divine-agents tradition.²²

This both explains how the author of 2 Maccabees could employ such language as well as supports Lau’s work concerning the possible understanding of the epiphanic terminology in the Greco-Roman sphere. After a careful treatment of the occurrences of the epiphanic terminology in the PE against this probable backdrop, Lau goes on to argue that far from subsuming Christology either under soteriology or *theology*, the PE’s author is able to “contemporize his teaching” in response to the crisis facing the church at Ephesus without breaking the conceptual bounds of “*incarnation and pre-existence found in the Pauline Son of God christology*” (*italics his*).²³

The importance of Lau’s study for our purposes lies in his reorientation of Hasler’s understanding of God in the PE. As an offshoot of his attempt to argue for the independent significance of the PE’s christology due to the probable OT theophanic backdrop behind their epiphanic terminology, Lau argues that the PE are far from the philosophically influenced view of God which emphasized the “die über Zeit und Raum erhabene *Jenseitigkeit* dieses Allergottes.”²⁴ Rather, the PE’s emphasis on the transcendence of God in the context of the epiphanic terminology undergirds his ability to intervene on the behalf of all people as an expression of his saving will. The transcendence of God becomes the platform from which his saving intervention in Christ on behalf of all men is made possible and effective.²⁵

3. *The Backdrop of False Teaching*

A second crucial element in any assessment of the PE’s *theology* is an understanding of the false teaching that forms its backdrop. It is the false teaching that shapes, in some manner, the author’s *theology*.

²² *Manifest*, 222.

²³ *Manifest*, 263.

²⁴ Hasler, “Epiphanie”, 195.

²⁵ Lau, *Manifest*, 272.

This can be inferred from the outset of 1 Timothy where the author sets the “other-teaching” of 1:3 over against the “plan of God” in 1:4.

Assessments of the false teaching differ widely. Basically, the field can be divided into four camps. The first sees the heresy as a mythical construct functioning as a paradigm for approaching heresy in any of its forms whenever and wherever it appears. The contacts with the PE’s *Sitz im Leben* exist only in that the author has drawn from heretical elements current in his time.²⁶ The second finds scholars on both sides of the authorship question arguing that the heresy is an amalgam of Jewish and Gnostic theological aberrations and their associated results.²⁷ The third sees some theological dimensions to the antagonists in the PE, but their lack of a defining center, along with apparent influence of local elites evident in the instructions to the rich and the language of the office codes, suggests that these antagonists were theological illiterates occupying the offices of the church by virtue of their social standing in secular society.²⁸ The final view understands the heresy to have a defined theological core out of which nearly all of the ethical consequences and the author’s response can be explained.²⁹

Space limitations will prohibit a careful treatment of the various options vying for the title, “assured result.”³⁰ However, it is a combination of the final two approaches, as developed primarily by P. Towner and R. Kidd, which seems most convincing.³¹ First, concerning Towner’s contribution, working from the data which cannot be lumped under the heading, “stock polemic,”³² he argues that the antagonists had

²⁶ E.g. H. Koester, *Introduction to the New Testament* 2 (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1982) 297-305.

²⁷ E.g. W. Schenk, “Die Briefe an Timotheus I und II und an Titus (Pastoralbriefe) in der neueren Forschung (1945-85)” in *ANRW* II, 25.4, ed. W. Haase (Berlin: De Gruyter, 1987) 3427-30 and J. N. D. Kelly, *The Pastoral Epistles* (Peabody: Hendrickson, 1987) 12.

²⁸ R. Kidd, *Beneficence*, 98.

²⁹ E.g. Towner, *Goal*, 21-45.

³⁰ For an overview of current views of the false teaching in the PE, see Towner, *Goal*, 21-45; R. J. Karris, “The Background and Significance of the Polemic of the Pastoral Epistles,” *JBL* 92 (1973) 549-64; F. Young, *Theology*, 5-20; and this author’s “God and Christian Existence in 1 and 2 Timothy and Titus” (Unpublished Ph.D. dissertation, Aberdeen Un., Scotland, 1992) 260-70.

³¹ Both Lau (*Manifest*, 24) and Marshall (“Christology of the Pastoral Epistles”, 163) have recently supported Towner’s over-realized eschatological position. See also the studies by W. Lane (“1 Tim IV:1-3. An Early Instance of Over-Realized Eschatology?” *NTS* 2 [1964] 164-7) and O. Skarsaune (“Heresy and the Pastoral Epistles,” *Themelios* 20/1 [1994] 9-14) who both argue for the prominence of an over-realized perspective in the heresy of the PE.

³² For a discussion of “traditional” or “stock” polemic from the Greco-Roman

largely taken the “not yet” out of the “already/not yet” tension of pauline eschatology. 2 Tim. 2:18, which reports that the antagonists were arguing that the “resurrection had already happened,” is the key to his reconstruction. Not only does he find historical precedence for the existence and impact of such an “over-realized eschatology” in 1 Corinthians (cf. 4:8; 15:12),³³ but he is able to link this theological aberration with the ethical and theological dimensions of the author’s attack against and prescription for the false teaching throughout the PE.³⁴

Thus their major theological error was soteriological in nature. Salvation was held to be fully obtainable “now”, though apparently . . . this claim required adopting a rather negative view of the paradoxically temporal world around them as well as a number of practices to keep the influences of that world in check.³⁵

As a result the churches at Ephesus and Crete had dramatically shifted in their understanding of the nature of God’s saving acts in Christ. They now had a very diminished expectation of the future and a heightened expectation of the “now”. They were in essence living the resurrected life on the spiritual plane. With regard to the fallout of such an understanding, as the analogous situation in Corinth demonstrates, this “‘eschatological’ dualism” can account for the ascetic tendencies evident in the false teachers’ prohibition of marriage and of certain foods (1 Tim. 4:1-3) as well as the emancipatory trend evident among women (1 Tim. 2:11-15; 3:11; 5:14; 2 Tim. 3:6-7; Tit. 2:4-5) and slaves (1 Tim. 6:1-2; Tit. 2:9-10).³⁶ With regard to the PE’s theology, the soteriological shift can also account for the relatively unique and persistent reference to God and Christ as “savior”,³⁷ for

perspective, compare the work of R. Karris, “Background”, 551-5, with that of L. T. Johnson, “2 Timothy and the Polemic Against False Teachers: A Re-examination”, *JReLS* 6/7 (1978/79) 1-26. Karris largely denies that the “traditional polemic” can offer much toward understanding the false teaching in the PE while Johnson takes a much less negative view. Note also the work of Skarsaune (“Heresy”, 10-11). With a nod to Karris’s work, he adds additional insights by taking the Jewish character of the opposition seriously. In particular, he argues that the non-traditional polemical elements referring to the false teaching in the PE fall nicely within the first century Jewish category of “heresy”.

³³ See A. Thiselton, “Realized Eschatology at Corinth,” *NJS* 24 (1977/78) 510-26.

³⁴ Towner is able to link the resurrection issue in 2 Tim. 2:18 directly to 1 Timothy by establishing the terminological and conceptual links between 2 Tim. 2:18 and 1 Tim. 6:20-21 (*Goal*, 30-31). Once this link has been established and the full dimensions of the author’s depiction of the false teaching and its implication are explored throughout 1 and 2 Timothy, it becomes readily apparent that the false teaching plaguing the church at Crete in Titus falls squarely within the same camp (*Goal*, 24-28).

³⁵ *Goal*, 32.

³⁶ *Goal*, 38-42.

³⁷ *Goal*, 49-56.

the emphasis on soteriology in the christological traditions employed and modified by the author,³⁸ and for the “epiphany schema” which re-locates the community’s expectation of the “now” by setting them between the two Christ-events which inaugurated and will consummate the present time of salvation.³⁹

Alongside Towner’s contribution is that of R. Kidd. At first read it would seem that the two are irreconcilable. Kidd argues that the false teaching is a result of the immaturity of men who have taken the offices within the church based on their standing in, and with a value grid informed by, secular society. He rightly emphasizes the language in the office codes which sets out standards pertaining to “urban notables”⁴⁰ as well as the instructions to the rich as important for a reconstruction of the false teachers.⁴¹ He strengthens his case by demonstrating the unity of 1 Tim. 6:3-21 which equates the οἱ βουλόμενοι πλουτεῖν of 6:3-10 with the τοῖς πλουσίοις of 6:17-19 and, consequently, locates them within the ranks of the false teachers.⁴² For Kidd, though he is unaware of Towner’s work, this explains why the false teaching defies systematization by so many. Their immaturity manifested itself in their disjointed hodge-podge of theological peculiarities.⁴³ They had attained their office in pursuit of, and based on, a set of values largely antithetical to what God demands of those filling such offices, i.e. the life of εὐσέβεια (1 Tim. 6:3,5,6,11).

However, Kidd’s position is not as irreconcilable with Towner’s as it might seem. It is not inconceivable, especially given the analogous situation in Corinth, that their immaturity could have included a developed, though incorrect, theology. Paul confronted the self-satisfied (1 Cor. 4:8) Corinthians with the charge of immaturity (1 Cor. 3:1), though it can be convincingly demonstrated that the various issues

³⁸ *Goal*, 79-119.

³⁹ *Goal*, 61-74.

⁴⁰ “The point is that the language that distinguishes the Pastorals within the New Testament is precisely that which the inscriptions and moralists employ to shape the civic virtue of urban notables” (*Beneficence*, 91; cf. 97-98).

⁴¹ *Beneficence*, 93-100.

⁴² Kidd first establishes the unity of 6:3-20 by demonstrating that Timothy (6:11-16) and the false teachers (6:3-10; 17-19) are to be reverse images of one another (*Beneficence*, 94-95). Second, he points to the “linear tense” of the infinitive πλουτεῖν which suggests that a rendering of “to maintain their wealth”, as opposed “to become rich”, is called for (*Beneficence*, 95-96; cf. W. Bauer, *et al.*, *BAGD* [Chicago: Un. of Chicago, 1979] 673). Finally, and in his mind most importantly, Kidd notes that the “burden” of 6:3-10, i.e. the denunciation of φιλαργυρία, occurs elsewhere only in the officer lists—“lists aimed at wealthy household heads” (*Beneficence*, 96).

⁴³ *Beneficence*, 97-98.

Paul confronts have a common core in an over-realized eschatology. Thus, there is no reason why the theological coherency of Towner's approach need be seen as incongruent with Kidd's secularized local elites. Kidd's perspective opens a window on the mechanism through which the false teachers ascended to the offices within the church, and also a prominent motivation behind their ascent. These were men used to leadership (and the churches very likely defined leadership in their terms) and very likely adept in the nuances of the *quid pro quo* patronage system of their times. At the same time, however, the air of competence surrounding their social interaction did not serve them well when they stepped into leadership within God's household,⁴⁴ a leadership that demanded a different set of values and skills consistent with εὐσέβεια. Towner fills in the view by demonstrating the resultant character of their unskilled, but confident, interaction with the OT scriptures and, thereby, making sense of the impact of their ministry on the community at large and of the PE's theologically grounded response.

In short, not only has Towner's and Kidd's work provided encouragement for seeing the PE as a creative, theologically sophisticated corpus, but they have also encouraged us to take the statements about God seriously with regard to their role in the author's response to the false teaching in Ephesus and Crete. Moreover, with a provisional acceptance of this hybrid reconstruction, an internal check is provided against which our attention to the PE's theology can be directed and assessed.

4. *The Immediate Context and Interconnections between the Contexts of 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16*

In order to understand the nature and function of the elaborate descriptions of God in 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16 it is necessary to see the larger, but immediate, contexts of each collocation of divine epithets as well as the relationship between these contexts. In doing so it will become apparent that the author very likely intended his readers to perceive the linkage between the 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16 and their immediate contexts as well as between the passages themselves. This re-enforces the growing trend toward recognizing the author's theological creativity and sophistication and steers us away from views

⁴⁴ Their self-confidence goes hand in hand with an improper treatment of the truth (1 Tim. 1:17; 6:4,17).

which de-emphasize a close attention to the epithets used for God or to the PE's *theology* itself. Moreover, it provides a broader framework which needs to be considered in assessing the nature and function of the collocation of epithets in 1:17 and 6:15-16.

Little direct work has been done on the structure of the book as a whole with the notable exception being the small article by P. Bush.⁴⁵ In particular, it is his development of the connections between 1 Tim. 1:12-20 and 6:11-16, 20-21 that warrant our interest. The main points of connection that Bush finds between these passages are: the conceptually similar "creedal forms" in 1:17 and 6:15-16; both 1:18 and 6:20 refer to a deposit placed in Timothy's trust; the vocative is used referring to Timothy in 1 Timothy only in 1:18 and 6:20; the structurally and conceptually similar phrases in 1:18 (στρατεύῃ ἐν αὐταῖς τὴν καλὴν στρατείαν ἔχων πίστιν) and 6:12 (ἀγωνίζου τὸν καλὸν ἀγῶνα τῆς πίστεως); in 1:18 and 6:12 Timothy's charge is to be carried out so as to be a witness to the community; and, finally, there is a note of warning in both 1:19 and 6:21 concerning those who have turned away. Using this as his starting point, he then proceeds to develop an overall structure for the letter from other internal clues. Since his structure of the book as a whole is outside our immediate concerns, we will leave that aside except where these other suggestions affect the relationship between 1 Timothy 1 and 6.

However, while the contribution by Bush provides a good starting point and the connection between 1 Timothy 1 and 6 is increasingly recognized,⁴⁶ there is room for some qualification of his results⁴⁷ as well as a need for a further refinement of that connection. Bush builds his approach off of the earlier work by J. Thuren.⁴⁸ However, he differs from Thuren who included 1 Tim. 1:3-11 and 6:3-10, 17-19 in developing the connection between 1 Timothy 1 and 6.⁴⁹ In Bush's view

⁴⁵ "A Note on the Structure of 1 Timothy," *NTS* 36 (1990) 152-6.

⁴⁶ E.g., see Towner, *Goal*, 30-31 and Lau, *Manifest*, 226.

⁴⁷ Initially, the need for revisiting Bush's work is evident in his implausible suggestion that 1 Tim. 6:17-19, a passage which finds no place in the parallelism he develops between 1 Timothy 1 and 6, is "probably misplaced as the result of a scribal error . . ." ("Structure", 155). There is no textual evidence to support such a claim. Furthermore, his linking of ταύτην τὴν παραγγελίαν παρατίθεμαί σοι of 1:18 and τὴν παραθήκην φύλαξον in 6:20 seems unlikely in light of the limited referent of the former in the context of the book, i.e. it refers to his particular charge at Ephesus (1:3). Whereas the latter is the larger category under which the particular task at Ephesus falls (cf. 2 Tim. 1:12, 14; Towner, *Goal*, 126; Lau, *Manifest*, 30).

⁴⁸ "Die Struktur der Schlussparänese 1 Tim. 6, 3-21," *TZ* 26 [1970] 241-53, esp. 242-4.

⁴⁹ Thuren basically argues that the whole of 1 Tim. 6:3-21 is carefully constructed

1 Tim. 1:3-11 provides the backdrop for the letter as a whole, with 1 Tim. 1:12-20 and 1 Tim. 6:11-16, 20-21 forming an *inclusio* framework.⁵⁰ However, the reasons Bush offers for his restriction of the relevant segments of 1 Timothy 1 and 6 are unconvincing.

First, with regard to 1 Timothy 1, Bush denies the parallelism between 1 Timothy 1:3-11 and 6 on the grounds that it merely describes Timothy's mission and antagonists without giving him something constructive to do or teach.⁵¹ Such a statement is plausible only if one argues that the instructions in 1 Tim. 1:4-5 were somehow vague to the original recipient or, in comparison with similar texts, e.g. 1 Tim. 3:16-4:11 (which seems to be Bush's point), that they are not as concrete. But given that Timothy understood what "myths and genealogies" were and how these contrasted with the "plan of God" rightly perceived (1:4), one wonders how much more constructive the author's comments could be than when he tells Timothy to shut down these aberrant perspectives which, he goes on to explain, arise from a misuse of the OT (1:7-11). This is especially so since the author gives a specific example of what this may entail in his dealings with Hymenaeus and Alexander (1:20). Moreover, the separating of 1 Tim. 1:3-11 from 12-20 is unlikely on structural grounds since the use of *παραγγέλλω* and its forms (1:3,4, & 18) ties the section closely together. This seems to be decisively confirmed by the position and consequent anaphoric force of *ταύτην* in 1:18a (*ταύτην τὴν παραγγελίαν παρατίθεμαί σοι*).

Second, from the parallels between 3:16-4:11, a questionable division unique to Bush's structure, and 6:2b-10,17-19, in particular the focus on *εὐσέβεια* as the antidote to the antagonists' approach, Bush seems to argue that this further rules out 1 Tim. 1:3-11 since it possesses no clear verbal links to the one other passage which instructs Timothy concerning the tenets of, and response to, the antagonists. This point depends entirely on his contention that 3:16-4:11 is a distinct unit. However, such a division is unlikely since the references to the author's "coming" (3:14; 4:13) extend the limits of this unit back to 3:14 and forward to 4:16. Additionally, 3:14-4:16 has a narrow focus on Timothy, in sharp contrast to that which precedes and follows, and concludes by encouraging Timothy to adhere to the truth/teaching (4:16) now being abandoned by the antagonists (4:1). Moreover, moving the sec-

so that the warning against greed in 6:3-10 provided the motivation for the instructions to the wealthy in 1 Tim. 6:17-19 ("Struktur", 241-4).

⁵⁰ "Structure", 155-6.

⁵¹ "Structure", 155-6.

tion back to 3:14 creates a clear link between 1:3-11 and the present section in the parallel between the necessity of promoting the οἰκονομία θεοῦ in 1:4 and the importance of knowing πῶς δεῖ ἐν οἴκῳ θεοῦ ἀναστρέφεισθαι in 3:14. This is particularly important for our understanding of εὐσέβεια in 3:14-4:16 and 6:3-21. It suggests a sense of development or extension of the author's conception of God's plan (οἰκονομίαν θεοῦ, 1:4)⁵² to be embodied by the "household of God" (οἶκῳ θεοῦ, 3:15), which is itself to be understood in terms of the distinctively pauline ἐκκλησία θεοῦ (3:15),⁵³ to embrace and qualify the author's understanding of εὐσέβεια. It is εὐσέβεια that becomes a shorthand expression for the quality of life demanded of the members of God's house. It is a life which arises from a response of faith to, and continues to be conditioned by, a proper understanding of the saving work of God in Christ (1 Tim. 3:16; cf. 1:11,15-16; 2:3-7;4:10). As a result, such a life promotes God's οἰκονομία, on the one hand, and provides the antidote to the antagonists' "over-realized" perspective (1 Tim. 4:8; 6:3,5,6), on the other hand.⁵⁴ Thus, it seems best to see the parallelism between 1 Timothy 1 and 6 necessarily to include 1 Tim. 1:3-11.

Moreover, given the appropriateness of including 1 Tim. 1:3-11 in any parallelism with 1 Timothy 6, there is no basis for Bush's limitation of the relevant material in 1 Timothy 6 to verses 11-16, 20-21. In particular, now that the connection between 1:3-11 and 3:14-4:16 has been established, there seem to be no grounds to eliminate 6:2b-10, 17-19 from the parallelism between 1 Timothy 1 and 6. 1 Tim. 3:14-4:16 make the connection between the οἰκονομία θεοῦ of 1:4 and

⁵² For a discussion of the meaning and interrelationship between οἰκονομία θεοῦ and οἶκος θεοῦ as, respectively, the arrangement of God for salvation (cf. Eph. 1:10; 3:16) and those who are in service of that plan (cf. 2 Tim. 2:20-21) read the discussion in Donelson, *Pseudepigraphy*, 133 and Young, *Theology*, 55 in light of Fee's comments (1 & 2 Timothy, *Titus*, 42, 48, 92). Fee adds precision to the nuances of the two terms without blurring them unnecessarily together as Donelson and Young are wont to do.

⁵³ Fee, *1 & 2 Timothy, Titus*, 92. The designation of the ἐκκλησία as θεοῦ occurs almost exclusively in Paul (e.g. Rom. 16:16; 1 Cor. 10:32; 11:16,22; 12:28; Gal. 1:13; 1 Thess. 2:14), with Acts 20:28 being the only exception. Even here, Luke demonstrates a close affinity to pauline conceptions (cf. K. Schmidt, "Ἐκκλησία", *TDNT* 3 [1965] 506-7). Moreover, the structure of 3:15, the agreement of the indefinite relative ἥτις with ἐκκλησία as opposed to the preceding οἶκῳ and the "advance" which takes place in the movement from οἶκῳ θεοῦ to ἐκκλησία θεοῦ ζῶντος, στῦλος καὶ ἐδραῖωμα τῆς ἀληθείας (B. S. Easton, *The Pastoral Epistles* [London: SCM, 1948] 136), points to the centrality of ἐκκλησία θεοῦ.

⁵⁴ See, Townner, *Goal*, 147-52; Bush, "Structure", 156; and H. von Lips, *Glaube-Gemeinde-Amt. Zum Verständnis der Ordination in den Pastoralbriefen* (FRLANT 122; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1979) 81-83.

εὐσέβεια so as to make sense of the author's presentation of εὐσέβεια as the antidote to the perspective of the false teachers in 6:2b-10. Kidd's modification and development of Thuren's argument for the unity of 1 Tim. 6:2b-21 further undergirds the necessity of including this whole section in any parallelism developed with 1T 1.⁵⁵ The individuals in 6:2b-10 are of a piece with "the rich" in 6:17-19 in relation to whom Timothy is to be the reverse image (6:11-16).⁵⁶

Finally, beyond the links already noted, there seem to be grounds for seeing a similarity in structure between 1 Timothy 1 and 6. There appears to be a sequential arrangement of conceptual units which is roughly paralleled in both passages. In addition, the hinge passage of 1 Tim. 3:14-4:16 seems to fall into this same pattern. Fig. 1 presents these divisions and links.⁵⁷

To sum up our work thus far, it seems best to add to the modified list of connections between 1 Timothy 1 and 6 noted by Bush in order to include those which emerge in 1 Tim. 1:3-11 and 6:2b-10. 1 Tim. 1:3-20 and 6:3-21 constitute distinct literary units. Moreover, this parallelism should be informed by 3:15-4:16 since it provides the link between key concepts in each.

5. *Role of, and Conception of God within, 1 Tim. 1:17; 6:15-16*

Now that the general parameters and nature of the connections between 1 Timothy 1 and 6 have been sufficiently established, it is time to consider the function and general nature of the language about God in 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16. This will bring together a consideration of their immediate contexts with the conception of God they portray and insights gained from the interconnection of 1 Timothy 1 and 6.

According to our division of these passages, both collocations of epithets fall at the conclusion of either the recollection of Paul's call or

⁵⁵ See note 42 above.

⁵⁶ Kidd, *Beneficence*, 94.

⁵⁷ Although this author has not developed the full outline here, there is a possibility of a chiasmic/concentric symmetrical structure emerging in 1 Timothy. For background of chiasmic/concentric symmetrical structure and Paul's letters, see B. Luter & M. Lee, "Philippians as Chiasmus: Key to the Structure, Unity and Theme Questions," *NTS* 41 (1995) 89-101; C. Blomberg, "The Structure of 2 Corinthians 1-7," *Criswell Theological Review* 4 (Fall, 1989) 4-8; and J. Harvey, *Listening to the Text: Oral Patterning in Paul's Letters* (Grand Rapids: Baker, 1998) 104-17, 287.

Fig. 1
Key Aspects of The
Defection and
Pointed Response

Key Aspects of The Defection and Pointed Response	1 Tim. 1:3-20 1:3-11	1 Tim. 3:14-4:16 3:14-4:5	1 Tim. 6:2b-21 6:2b-10
*Attacks OT Perversion of "Some" (1:3,6)	*Attacks Asceticism of "Some" (4:1)	*Corrects "Money-Love" of "Some" (6:3,10)	*Eὐσέβεια, set alongside the "words of Christ Jesus", as the Alternative (6:3,5,6)
*Promotion of God's οἰκονομία (1:4), with its Christological core (1:15), ³⁸ as the Alternative	*Instruction for Living ἐν οἴκῳ θεοῦ (=ἐκκλησία θεοῦ), which is grounded in the Christologically focused τὸ τῆς εὐσεβείας μυστήριον (3:15-16), as the Alternative	*Timothy exhorted to be a good διάκονος Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ (4:6)	*The God Designed Intent for Timothy's Contribution to God's Saving Work (6:11-13, 15-16): "Keep the commandment spotless, etc." (6:14), which the context suggests is equivalent to the ἐπιταβὴ τῆς αἰωνίου ζωῆς (6:12) or the εὐσέβεια μετὰ ἀνταρκειᾶς (6:6). ³⁹ This makes Timothy, in his focus on "real life"/ "godliness with contentment", the reverse image of the wealth-obsessed antagonists.
Personal Call/ Charge from God	1:12-17	4:6-10	6:11-16
*Paul placed εἰς διακονίαν by Christ Jesus (1:12)	*The God Designed Intent of Paul's Contribution to God's Saving Work (1:11,15,17): To be a ὑποτάκσις of Christ's Patience for all those yet to believe εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον. At the same time, this makes Paul an encouragement for Timothy and the reverse image of the OT-based Antagonism, i.e. he used to be a blasphemer (1:12) like Hymenaeus and Alexander (1:20).	*Timothy exhorted to be a good διάκονος Χριστοῦ Ἰησοῦ (4:6)	*Timothy exhorted to confess the same καλὴν ὁμολογίαν (6:12,13) to which Christ bore witness
*The God Designed Intent of Paul's Contribution to God's Saving Work (1:11,15,17): To be a ὑποτάκσις of Christ's Patience for all those yet to believe εἰς ζωὴν αἰώνιον. At the same time, this makes Paul an encouragement for Timothy and the reverse image of the OT-based Antagonism, i.e. he used to be a blasphemer (1:12) like Hymenaeus and Alexander (1:20).	*The Charge at Ephesus Enjoined (τὴν τὴν παραγγελίαν παρατίθεμαι σοι; 1:18) with an Explicit Reference to the Antagonists (1:20)	*Call to Fulfill the Charge at Ephesus (παραγγελλε; 4:11) with an Implicit Reference to the Antagonists (1:12)	*Call to Fulfill the Charge at Ephesus (παραγγελλε; 6:17; cf. 13) with an Explicit Reference to the Antagonists (6:17-19,21)
Stand Strong in Your Opposition by Holding to Your Call	1:18-20	4:11-16	6:17-21

³⁸ "The kerygmatic formula of 1 Tim. 1:15 is no mere formal citation. . . . It serves as the linchpin of the entire section. . . ." (Lau, *Manifest*, 71).
³⁹ 6:12a, ἀγωνίζου τὸν καλὸν ἀγῶνα τῆς πίστεως, appears to be shorthand for the more detailed instructions in 6:11 concerning Timothy's

Timothy's charge with regard to his ministry at Ephesus.⁶⁰ However, there are some differences in their relationships with their contexts. 1:17 includes its collocation of epithets within a doxology, thus providing no clear syntactical link to the passage, whereas 6:15-16 incorporates its collocation into the sentence beginning at v. 13. In other words, the extended description of God in 6:15-16, as the one who sets the time of Christ's epiphany and, consequently, of Timothy's assessment before God, provides the ultimate inducement for Timothy's pursuit of eternal life (vv. 12-14).⁶¹ This has suggested to some that the connection between 1:17 and 6:15-16 is not so much on the functional level, but merely on the level that similar views of God are found in each. 1:17 is little more than rhetorical flourish occasioned by the author's recollection of God's mercy in Christ.⁶² However, when 1:17 is examined in light of the companion passages of 4:6-10 and 6:11-16, there are grounds for doubting such an assessment. Since it is the connection and significance of 1:17 that is most in contention, we will give it the lion's share of our treatment and elaborate on 6:15-16 more indirectly in the context of our comments on 1:17.

To begin with a look at 4:6-10, it seems that it concludes in a manner conceptually similar to 6:15-16 in that Timothy's pursuit and promotion of εὐσέβεια finds its ground in Paul and Timothy's common

response to the issues at Ephesus. As such it is very similar to the role of the parallel phrase in 1:18, 19a, ἵνα στρατεύῃ ἐν αὐταῖς τὴν καλὴν στρατείαν ἔχων πίστιν καὶ ἀγαθὴν συνείδησιν. In its context, this phrase entails Timothy's particular charge at Ephesus which is itself set within, and is an outworking of, God's saving work (1:4), a work that focuses on belief in Christ unto eternal life (1:16). Against this backdrop, 6:12b, ἐπιλαβοῦ τῆς αἰωνίου ζωῆς, becomes a restatement and clarification of 6:12a and the climax which calls forth the elaboration of 12c and the strong adjuration of 6:13-16. The centrality of this phrase is confirmed, moreover, by the condemnation of the temporal perspective of the antagonists (6:7,17), a condemnation which sandwiches the whole of 6:11-16, and by the fact that the prescribed remedy for this temporal mind set is a lifestyle driven by the pursuit of "real life", ἵνα ἐπιλάβωνται τῆς ὄντως ζωῆς (6:19). With regard to εὐσέβεια μετὰ αὐταρκειᾶς of 6:5, when it is recognized that the antagonists in 6:3-10 are the same group mentioned in 6:17-19, it becomes an alternative, shorthand expression for the greatly elaborated "laying hold of eternal life," i.e. the manner of life which forms the reverse image of and antidote for the lifestyle of the antagonists.

⁶⁰ The regular use of the doxology as a concluding formula throughout the NT makes the divisions of 1 Timothy 1 and 6 at v. 17 and v. 16, respectively, very likely (cf. R. Deichgräber, *Gotteshymnus und Christushymnus in der frühen Christenheit* [SUNT 5; Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1967] 34 and L. G. Champion, *Benedictions and Doxologies in the Epistles of Paul* [Oxford: By the Author, 1934] 36).

⁶¹ See n. 59 above.

⁶² E.g. Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 55.

hope in “the living God, who is the Savior of all who believe” (4:10; cf. 2:1-7).⁶³ The argument here is that the author has developed his concept of God carefully over the first three chapters so that this phrase in 4:10,⁶⁴ which is certainly not obviously as elaborate as 1:17 or 6:15-16, is nonetheless conceptually (and, as we will see, functionally) parallel to those passages. The “Savior” of 4:10 is to be understood in terms of the transcendent God of 1:11,17. This connection is made within the context of 1 Timothy 1. The “King of the Ages, etc.” of 1:17, to whom the author offers praise, is the “blessed God” (1:11) whose “glory” is the content of the “gospel,”⁶⁵ the historical work of Christ which Paul experienced (1:14-15,16) and now propagates as a living pattern for all those yet to believe on Christ (1:11,12,16).⁶⁶ The gospel entrusted to Paul is then taken up again in 2:1-7 (esp. v. 7), but this time the transcendent God of 1:11,17 has become the “God our Savior” of 2:3-6, which is itself explained in terms of the “One God” common to pauline soteriology (2:5).⁶⁷ Moreover, as the historical work of Christ is the “glory of the blessed God” enshrined in the gospel entrusted to Paul in 1:11, so the work of Christ, the giving of himself as a “ransom for all” at God’s appointed time (2:6),⁶⁸ is the

⁶³ For this rendering of the enigmatic μάλιστα with the sense of “namely”, “to be precise”, see T. C. Skeat, “Especially the Parchments: A Note on 2 Tim. 4:13,” *JTS* 30 (1979) 173-7 and I. H. Marshall, “Universal Grace and Atonement in the Pastoral Epistles” in *The Grace of God, The Will of Man*, ed. C. Pinnock (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 1989) 55.

⁶⁴ The “faithful saying” of 4:9 is most likely 4:8b, ἡ δὲ εὐσέβεια πρὸς πάντα ὠφέλιμος ἐστὶν ἐπαγγελίαν ἔχουσα ζωῆς τῆς νῦν καὶ τῆς μελλούσης. 4:10 is grammatically dependent upon 4:8 and 4:8a appears to function only so as to set up the contrast for what follows in 8b (Fee, *1&2 Timothy, Titus*, 105; Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 101). Moreover, our study of the structure of the letters points to the centrality of ζωῆς τῆς νῦν καὶ τῆς μελλούσης for the argument of the letter as a whole (cf. 1:16; 6:12-13,19; & Fig. 1 above). Given that 4:8b is the “faithful saying”, it is interesting as well that 4:10 follows close on its heels in a manner reminiscent of the relationship between 1:17 and the “faithful saying” in 1:15.

⁶⁵ Knight (*Pastoral Epistles*, 90-91) notes the parallel to the phrasing in 2 Cor. 4:4 where the glory of God manifested in Christ is the content of Paul’s kerygma (cf. Lietzmann, *An Die Korinther I/II* [HNT 9; Tübingen: Mohr, 1949] 115).

⁶⁶ Cf. Lau, *Manifest*, 69,71.

⁶⁷ While the “One God” does not occur here in the context of the Jew/Gentile controversy as in Rom. 3:20 or Gal. 2:20, it nevertheless reproduces the apostle Paul’s soteriological deduction from that confession in those passages in that it functions as the ground for the universal character of the salvation offered by the Savior (2:4; Towner, *Goal*, 50-51; P. Trummer, *Die Paulustradition der Pastoralbriefe* [BBET 8; Frankfurt am Main: Lang, 1978] 139; Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 63).

⁶⁸ For this rendering of καιροῖς ἰδίοις to designate the event to which it is appended as divinely determined and, in this context, as proceeding from God’s saving will, see

“factual proof” (τὸ μαρτύριον) of God’s desire to save all men (cf. Rom. 3:24-25) which is entrusted to Paul in 2:7.⁶⁹ Thus, the description of God in 4:10, read in light of its development in 1 Timothy 1 and 2, takes it place alongside 1 Tim. 1:17 and 6:15-16 as a heavily loaded *theological* statement. Moreover, this establishment of the connection to 1 Tim. 2:3-7 is important for our understanding of the key terms in 1 Timothy 1 as we now go on to establish just what sort of God is in view and how this conception of God functions in its immediate context and in relationship to 1 Tim. 6:15-16.

In 1 Timothy 1, the “blessed God” and the “King of the Ages, etc.” do indeed appear to overlap in their emphasis on God’s sovereignty and saving character as might be expected by their connection to 1 Tim. 2:1-7; 4:10. However, the former has not always been seen as an aspect of God that relates to his redemptive governance of the world, but as a quality stressing his aloofness from the world. As B. S. Easton defines it, μακάριος as a divine predicate betrays strong Hellenistic influence and suggests “freedom from evil and care, almost ‘happy,’ in contrast to humans.”⁷⁰ This seems confirmed in that elsewhere in the NT, LXX, and other early writings μακάριος is predominantly used with reference to those who have benefitted from divine favor (e.g. Ps. 31(32):1-2; 2 Chr. 9:7; Luke 1:45; Rom. 14:22) or, secondarily, to a state or quality of impersonal things, a state or quality usually associated with a proper response to God (e.g. 4 Macc. 12:1; Matt. 13:16; Acts 20:35; 1 Clem. 35:1). What is hard to find is the use of this term as a divine predicate. Nonetheless, it is not hard to see how the God who makes blessed can become the God who is blessed.⁷¹ Indeed, from passages such as Josephus, *Antiquitates* 10.278, where the “blessed and immortal nature” is the chosen designation for God within a passage affirming God’s providential ordering of the world, it is clear that the quality of “blessedness” has been incorporated into the transcendent, yet immanent conception of God which

J. Roloff, *Der erste Brief an Timotheus* (EKK 15; Zürich: Benziger, 1988) 123-4; Fee, *1 & 2 Timothy, Titus*, 66; Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 64; and A. J. Malherbe, “‘In Season and Out of Season’: 2 Timothy 4:2,” *JBL* 103/2 (1984) 243.

⁶⁹ See Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 64; Towner, *Goal*, 83; E. F. Scott, *The Pastoral Epistles* (London: Hodder & Stoughton, 1948) 22.

⁷⁰ *Pastoral Epistles* (London: SCM, 1948) 179-80; cf. M. Dibelius & H. Conzelmann, *The Pastoral Epistles* (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1972) 25-26, 30 n. 22.

⁷¹ This phenomenon can be understood in light of such passages as Ps. 119:68 where that which is accomplished by God is spoken of as a concrete expression of his character.

pervades the Scriptures generally. But, what is even more significant for our study is the intimate connection that μακάριος sustains with God's saving acts in Christ throughout the PE. In I Tim. 6:15a it is the "blessed and only sovereign" who will "make manifest" the consummation of the present time of salvation in the epiphany of Christ (cf. 2 Tim. 4:1). This event is fittingly designated as "the blessed hope" in Tit. 2:13. With regard to 1:11, as we have already mentioned, the "glory of the blessed God" is the content of the "gospel." The coming of Christ "into the world to save sinners" is the explication of this "glory", an event that is elsewhere referred to as the epiphany of "our Savior, Christ Jesus" (2 Tim. 1:10). Even though the epiphanic terminology is not used in 1 Tim. 1:15, the phrase ἦλθεν εἰς τὸν κόσμον falls within the OT theophanic framework,⁷² which Lau has convincingly demonstrated to be the backdrop of the epiphanic terminology in the PE,⁷³ and, thus, may be taken as a synonym for epiphany. Consequently, even though the use of μακάριος as a divine predication betrays hellenistic influence, the author's use of the term within 1 Timothy, in particular, demonstrates that the "aloofness" associated with the term is to be understood in terms of the transcendent/immanent tension generally prevalent in the Scriptures. This seems especially so given the aforementioned connection of this "blessed God" to the "savior" of 1 Tim. 2:3 and 4:10. The "blessed God" is the God who sets the parameters of his "saving plan" (καιροῖς ἰδίοις, 2:6; 6:15; Tit. 1:3; cf. 1 Tim. 1:1; 2 Tim. 1:9; Tit. 1:2) and acts "to save" through the willing participation of Christ (1 Tim. 2:6; 4:1).

As μακάριος has overtones of transcendence which have been tempered by its association with God's redemptive acts in Christ, the same can be said of the collocation of epithets in 1:17. First, it must be noted that 1:17 sustains a close relationship with 1:11. It is the doxology in 1:17 which concludes the section which explicates what the author means by the phrase, ὃ ἐπιστεύθην ἐγώ, in 1:11.⁷⁴ In addition, a close association is confirmed by the inclusion of μακάριος within 6:15-16, a passage which is connected to 1:17 functionally and forms nearly a mirror image of its conception of God (see Fig. 2).

⁷² See F. Schnutenhaus, "Das Kommen und Erscheinen Gottes im Alten Testament," *ZAW* 76 (1964) 1-22.

⁷³ *Manifest*, 66, 179-225.

⁷⁴ Fee, *1 & 2 Timothy, Titus*, 50.

Fig. 2	1 Tim. 1:17	1 Tim. 6:15-16
God Exercises a Benevolent Rule	τῷ βασιλεῖ τῶν αἰώνων	ὁ μακάριος καὶ μόνος δυνάστης, ὁ βασιλεὺς τῶν βασιλευόντων καὶ κύριος τῶν κυριευόντων
God is the Source of Immortality	ἀφθάρτῳ . . . μόνῳ θεῷ	ὁ μόνος ἔχων ἀθανασίαν
God cannot be seen	ἀοράτῳ	φῶς οἰκῶν ἀπρόσιτον, ὃν εἶδεν οὐδεὶς ἀνθρώπων οὐδὲ ἰδεῖν δύναται

This latter observation is important for our main point as well. It appears that 1:17 not only has a concluding function similar to the collocation of 6:15-16, but these passages are conceptually intertwined, with 6:15-16 arguably being a clarification/extension of the epithets for God in 1:11,17.⁷⁵ This should be of no surprise now that the author's general tendency toward development and extension has been demonstrated in the relationship between 1 Tim. 1:3-20, 3:14-4:16, and 6:2b-21. As such, it confirms the suspicion that 1:17 has a closer connection to the preceding paragraph than what is often suggested and that the doxology as a whole has no 'throw-away' epithets.⁷⁶ This lends credibility to the observation of some that τῷ βασιλεῖ τῶν αἰώνων may have been chosen by the author as a compliment to the ζῶν αἰώνιον of 1:16.⁷⁷ Thus, the King of the Ages is intricately linked to that which represents the goal toward which God's redemptive acts in Christ are directed, a linkage which is consistent with what we have found for 4:10 (cf. 4:8) and 6:15-16 (cf. 6:12-13).

Although we could possibly proceed further in this vein, it seems appropriate to draw our investigation of 1 Tim. 1:17; 6:15-16 and their immediate contexts to a close at this point. It is apparent that

⁷⁵ It has long been recognized that 6:15-16 presents God in more traditional Jewish terms (cf. Fee, *1 & 2 Timothy, Titus*, 152-4; A. T. Hanson, *The Pastoral Epistles* (NCBC; Eerdmans: Grand Rapids, 1982) 62,112). For example, the "invisible" God of 1:17 is the God "whom no one has seen or can see" in 6:16 which accords more directly with common OT motifs (Ex. 33:20; Isa. 6:1-5). Therefore, if the author intended these passages to be read together with 6:15-16 being the more elaborated development of these epithets, there is still less room for seeing a conception of God in these passages out of sync with the transcendent/immanent God of Paul and the Scriptures generally. Moreover, it leaves one increasingly puzzled as to how Hanson could say that the author "was no great theologian" (*Pastoral Epistles*, 62).

⁷⁶ Cf. Stettler, *Christologie*, 60.

⁷⁷ Kelly, *Pastoral Epistles*, 55; cf. Knight, *Pastoral Epistles*, 105.

the author intended 1:17 and 6:15-16 to be seen in relationship to one another both on the conceptual and the functional level. Both link their transcendent, conceptually intertwined portrayals of God to God's inaugurating and consummating redemptive acts in Christ as well as to his calling of Paul and Timothy for the propagation of that redemptive plan through the proclamation of the gospel. Moreover, this relationship is further confirmed by the tight linkage between these passages and the "Savior" in 2:3-7 and 4:10. Given these connections the portrayals of God in 1 Tim. 1:11,17 and 6:15-16 should not be seen as Hellenistic conceptions which contravene the transcendent/immanent conception of God which predominates in Paul⁷⁸ and the Scriptures generally. This is a God whose transcendence is not an aloofness, but a transcendence that undergirds and reenforces his redemptive governance.

And not only does this seem to be the clear import of these passages, but when they are seen against the backdrop of the false teaching as previously developed, they form a potent counterpunch to those teaching that God saves in a way other than that taught by Paul and Timothy. God the Savior, the unchallenged sovereign over his redemptive plan, has acted in Christ and will act in Christ all in accordance with his plan. Moreover, his acts extend to entrusting individuals, particularly Paul and Timothy, with the proclamation of "the gospel of the glory of the blessed God" (1 Tim. 1:11). As such, the over-realized eschatological perspective of the false teachers needs to be reassessed and brought back into line with the pauline already/not yet eschatological tension. They are living in the "in-between times," the times between the "set-in-stone" epiphanies of Christ. The first "epiphany" inaugurated the present time of salvation and the second, future "epiphany" will consummate it, a consummation which will involve an evaluation of each believers contribution to God's οἰκονομία (1 Tim. 6:15; cf. 5:21, 24-25; 2 Tim. 4:1,8). The resurrection and all that it holds for the believer are yet primarily in the future with even the present, the "now" of their life in Christ which is of a piece with that which is "to come" (1 Tim. 4:8), conditioned by the future judgment. A shift in emphasis from the past to the future is intended to re-orient their life within, and engagement with, the created world. No longer are God's creative purposes at odds with his redemptive purposes, the created world with its God-given institutions are not vestiges of the

⁷⁸ D. Guthrie and R. P. Martin, "God" in *The Dictionary of Paul and His Letters*, ed. R. P. Martin and G. F. Hawthorne (Downers Grove: IVP, 1993) 355.

old age now passing away, but gifts to be received with thanksgiving (1 Tim. 4:3-4) and to be used in promotion of "real life" (1 Tim. 6:17-19). Timothy can thus be encouraged to hold fast to what he has been taught so as to silence his socially powerful opponents and to promote God's saving plan.

6. *Conclusion*

Our focus on a limited portion of the author's *theology* has confirmed his creativity and theological sophistication. There seems to be no basis for seeing the author as a purveyor of clumsily juxtaposed *theological* goods. On both the macro and micro levels the author carefully develops and extends his conception of God in order to undercut, and provide the alternative for, the false teaching. Moreover, God is at the center of the discussion. It is God and how he saves that is at issue. Christology is central to his presentation of God and is by no means swallowed up by *theology*. Nonetheless, an understanding of how Christ's work relates to God's redemptive plan is of equal importance in comparison to an understanding of the nature of Christ's work in and of itself. It is the ministry of Christ that has been and will be done in accordance with God's plan, as must the ministries of Paul, Timothy, and anyone who desires to lead God's household. So also for every believer, all of life is conditioned by God's "house rules." It must be a life which arises from a response of faith to a proper understanding of the saving work of God in Christ.